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NEO Curriculum — Intent, Implementation and Impact

A structured online curriculum, shaped around the young person.

Status. This is a working draft — a **greenprint**, not a blueprint. It is meant to be grown, argued with, and refined with the people building the subject curricula. Nothing here is settled doctrine; the sections marked *proposed* are first passes offered for the Head of School and subject leads to take, leave, or reshape. Cornerstone definitions, Modes and the Mastery scale are quoted from the live **Teaching and Learning Policy v04.26** and remain subordinate to it. Where this document and a signed policy ever disagree, the signed policy wins.

Purpose of this document

This is the curriculum keystone for Nudge Education Online (NEO). Every subject curriculum — starting with mathematics — hangs off it. It sets out three things, in the language OEAS and commissioners expect:

- **Intent** — what NEO's curriculum is *for*, and what we believe a curriculum *is*.
- **Implementation** — how that intent is delivered, day to day, across live teaching, the platform, and the curriculum vault.
- **Impact** — how we know it is working, for this young person, this term.

It is written for three readers at once: the subject teams building the curriculum, the OEAS accreditation panel assessing whether it holds together, and the commissioners deciding whether to trust a young person to it.

NEO is the fully online alternative provision operated by **Nudge Education Ltd**, launching September 2026 for learners aged 11 to 18. It pursues **OEAS accreditation** — it is not a DfE-registered independent school and is not subject to ISI inspection. The first intakes in September 2026 are a Year 9 and a Year 10 cohort, with further year groups opening progressively.

Part 1 — Intent

1.1 Connection before curriculum. Always.

Most learners arrive at NEO having experienced education as something that hurt them. Emotionally based school non-attendance (EBSNA), disrupted placements, unmet need, time out of learning altogether. So the curriculum does not begin with content. It begins with trust, regulation, and re-learning that it is safe to show up. The structured curriculum starts *underneath* that, not on top of it.

This is not a soft preamble to the "real" curriculum. It is the first design constraint on all of it. A curriculum that is broad, balanced and ambitious but that a frightened learner cannot enter has failed at the first step. The pedagogy is trauma-informed; the posture is needs-led, not deficit-framed; the aim, always, is re-engagement — with learning, with self, with others.

1.2 What we believe a curriculum *is*

NEO holds a specific and deliberate position: **an exam specification describes assessment, not learning.**

The National Curriculum, and the awarding bodies' specifications, tell you how learning gets *tested* by external bodies. They do not, on their own, tell you what learning *is* for a young person. Conflating the two is the ordinary mistake of mainstream schooling — teaching the test and calling it the curriculum — and it is one of the things that broke education for many of our learners.

So NEO's curriculum runs on two axes, encoded in the Curriculum Vault as the **Curriculum × Overlay** model:

- The **Curriculum spine** is the canonical layer — *what learning is*. It is drawn from the National Curriculum where a strong one exists (Key Stage 3), from a synthesis across awarding bodies where it does not (Key Stage 4), and from NEO-original or statutory frames where neither applies (life-and-work skills, relational and symbolic literacy, the RSHE statutory strand).
- The **Overlay layer** maps awarding-body specifications — Pearson Edexcel International GCSE, AQA GCSE, Pearson Edexcel Functional Skills, ASDAN — onto that spine. Many overlays can point at the same canonical content. A learner is *taught* against the canonical spine and *assessed* against whichever overlay fits their pathway.

The point of the architecture is to make visible the gap between what is *useful* and what is *testable* — and then to equip learners to navigate the assessed world without letting that world own their record of learning. It also lets the same curriculum serve very different readers — a homeschooling family, a local authority, an online school, NEO itself — each entering from the angle they need.

1.3 The Six Cornerstones as the spine of *how* we teach

If the Curriculum spine is *what* is learned, the **Six Cornerstones** are *how* it is designed and taught. They are NEO's named pedagogical framework — the framing layer that sits across every subject, every mode, every session. Wellbeing and learning are the same activity, not a sequence.

The Cornerstones are defined in the Teaching and Learning Policy v04.26. As learner-facing framing they are:

1. **Connection** — relationships, communication, understanding self and others.
2. **Movement** — physical activity, embodied learning, energy regulation.
3. **Creativity** — making, exploring, originality, play.
4. **Reflection** — pausing to notice, metacognition, self-knowledge.
5. **Rest** — recovery, pacing, sustainable engagement.
6. **Nutrition** — fuelling body and brain, food literacy.

Until now the Cornerstones have done two jobs well: they anchor Friday Cornerstones Day, and they act as the framing tag on every node in the Curriculum Vault. What this document proposes is the third job: that the Cornerstones become the explicit **design principles for academic curriculum content itself** — the lens each subject lead uses to build lessons — replacing the "Ways of Knowing" scaffold inherited from the Verse-al curriculum.

Why the change from "Ways of Knowing"

NEO's first subject curriculum — mathematics — was originally authored (as *Verse-al Maths*, The Novacene Ltd) on five **Ways of Knowing**: the Knowing World, the Human Story, the Expressive Self, the Designed World, the Living Body. It is a beautiful frame. But it is a *second* framework sitting alongside the Cornerstones, and asking teachers to hold both is one framework too many. Every hour spent training staff on the Ways of Knowing is an hour not spent embedding the Cornerstones that already run through the whole school. The decision, therefore, is to re-base the maths curriculum — and every subsequent subject — onto the Cornerstones, and to retire the parallel scaffold.

This is not a clean one-to-one swap. There are five Ways and six Cornerstones, and the mapping has genuine seams. The section below is a **proposed first pass** — offered for the maths partner and Heads of Department to refine, not to impose.

1.4 The Cornerstones as curriculum design principles (*proposed first pass*)

Each Cornerstone is expressed here as a **design question** — the question it asks of any piece of content — followed by what it asks of a lesson, a worked example in mathematics, and an honest note on where the fit is strong or strained. Fit is deliberately uneven; that is expected. The Vault already records this with fit ratings (●●● strong, ●● partial, ● light), and this document adopts the same honesty.

Connection — *"What relationships does this learning live inside?"*

Learning happens through genuine engagement with other perspectives, and through the relational structure of the subject itself. A lesson designed for Connection makes the relationships visible — between ideas, and between people — and builds in dialogue, teach-back, and shared reasoning rather than solitary transmission.

In mathematics: mathematics is, at root, the study of relationships — equivalence, ratio and proportion, a function as a relationship between quantities, the dependency between variables. Connection also absorbs the old *Human Story* Way of Knowing: whose problem is this, where did this idea come from, who does it serve. Learners explain their reasoning to another person and are assessed partly on that explanation.

Fit: ●●● Strong across most of maths, and central to all live-mode delivery.

Movement — *"How does this idea move, and how can the learner move with it?"*

Knowledge is enacted and dynamic; ideas transform. A lesson designed for Movement treats concepts as things that change and can be traced through change, and — where possible online — invites the learner to move with them (gesture, manipulatives, the number line walked rather than read).

In mathematics: transformations, and above all the mathematics of change. Calculus is the mathematics of movement: velocity and acceleration, the chord that becomes a tangent as the interval shrinks to nothing, the limiting value. The first lessons of the Pure strand already teach differentiation as the study of instantaneous change — Movement made rigorous.

Fit: ●●● Strong in calculus, transformations, kinematics and graphing; ● lighter in some static number work — flag for the maths partner.

Creativity — *"What can the learner make, conjecture, or express with this?"*

Learners construct and express; they make mistakes freely and build things. A lesson designed for Creativity offers more than one route to a solution, invites conjecture before confirmation, and gives the learner something to make. This Cornerstone absorbs the old *Designed World* and *Expressive Self* Ways of Knowing.

In mathematics: multiple solution paths held side by side; conjecture-and-test before proof; mathematical modelling ("what can I build with this?"); choosing how to represent a result. Creativity is where a learner shows understanding in their own way rather than the one canonical way.

Fit: ●● Partial-to-strong; strongest in problem-solving, modelling and open tasks.

Reflection — *"Where does the learner step back to notice their own thinking?"*

Learning includes noticing how you learn. A lesson designed for Reflection builds in the pause: justification, proof, the deliberate surfacing and repair of misconceptions, and metacognitive review. This Cornerstone carries the reflective, proof-facing edge of the old *Knowing World*.

In mathematics: proof and justification ("explain *why*, not just *what*"); working with common misconceptions in the open (treating a histogram like a bar chart; height as frequency rather than density); teach-back as evidence of understanding rather than mere completion.

Fit: ●●● Strong — proof, reasoning and misconception work are native to good maths teaching.

Rest — *"Where is the space — for consolidation, for regulation, for the concept of nothing?"*

Sustainable engagement depends on recovery and pacing. A lesson designed for Rest is chunked, sensory-load-aware, and paced for a nervous system that may not tolerate a full mainstream load. It leaves room for consolidation and low-stakes retrieval rather than relentless new content.

In mathematics: pacing and sensory load are first-class design fields (the lesson metadata already carries `sensory_load: low | medium | high` and pacing options). And, more poetically, Rest is where mathematics meets the concept of **zero — nothing, the void, empty space**: place value and the role of zero, the empty set, limits tending to nothing, the null result. Rest is both a wellbeing design constraint and a genuine mathematical idea.

Fit: ●● Partial as content (zero, null, space), ●●● Strong as a pervasive pacing and regulation constraint on every lesson.

Nutrition — *"What real-world nourishment grounds this learning?"*

Fuelling the body and brain, food literacy, healthy habits — and, more broadly, the real-world contexts (health, sustainability, the body) that give abstract learning something to feed on. This is the hardest Cornerstone to map onto abstract academic content, and we should say so plainly.

In mathematics: ratio and proportion in recipes and nutrition; statistics and data handling on health; financial literacy of a food budget; Sustainable Development Goal contexts (Zero Hunger, Good Health). Nutrition sits most naturally in *applied and contextual* maths and in Cornerstones Day, rather than in every abstract concept — and it should not be forced where it does not belong.

Fit: ● Light in pure content, ●● Partial in applied/statistical/financial contexts, ●●● Strong on Cornerstones Day. **Open question for the maths partner and Heads of Department:** should Nutrition be treated as a genuine design lens for every subject, or accepted as a primarily contextual and Cornerstones-Day Cornerstone for the more abstract subjects? A defensible position either way — flagged, not resolved.

1.5 Subject-agnostic skills (*proposed scaffold*)

Alongside the Cornerstones, NEO intends to name a small set of **cross-curricular capabilities** — the through-lines a learner builds *regardless* of subject, so that "what is number sense,

really?" or "what is critical thinking in this subject?" has a shared answer across the school. These make progress legible across a fragmented timetable and support the portable portfolio.

Proposed starting set — **for agreement with Heads of Department, not yet fixed:**

- **Sense-making** — number sense, textual sense, pattern recognition; building intuition before formalism.
- **Reasoning and justification** — constructing an argument, proving, evaluating a claim.
- **Communication and representation** — explaining thinking; choosing and moving between representations.
- **Creative problem-solving** — approaching the unfamiliar; modelling; more than one route.
- **Metacognition and self-regulation** — noticing one's own thinking, pacing, and strategy.
- **Ethical and relational literacy** — engaging with others, and with technology, thoughtfully and safely.

Each capability should map loosely onto Cornerstones (for example, Reasoning ↔ Reflection; Communication ↔ Connection; Creative problem-solving ↔ Creativity) so the two frameworks reinforce rather than compete. This section is a scaffold: the substance is the Heads of Department's to author.

1.6 Breadth, balance and ambition — for every learner

The curriculum is broad, balanced and genuinely ambitious. The Pearson Edexcel International GCSE spine gives globally recognised academic qualifications; life-and-work skills, relational and symbolic literacy, and the RSHE statutory strand sit *alongside* it as canonical curriculum in their own right, not as consolation routes. Ambition is not lowered for learners who have missed education — it is *sequenced* so they can reach it. "Year 9" at NEO may mean filling fundamental gaps from earlier key stages; "Year 10" is best understood as *Year 1 of the iGCSE course*. We meet the young person where they are and build from there.

Part 2 — Implementation

2.1 Modes of delivery

The Teaching and Learning Policy v04.26 defines three **Modes**, and every piece of curriculum is designed for at least one:

- **Live** — live lessons via Google Meet, delivered by qualified, subject-specialist teachers.

- **Asynchronous** — Google Classroom courses, assignments and resources.
- **Independent** — learner-led projects and independent exploration.

Everything remains navigable without AI and without a live adult present, so that a learner is never wholly dependent on being online at a fixed time to make progress.

2.2 The teaching week

- **Monday to Thursday** — four 45-minute live sessions per day via Google Meet, delivered by qualified subject-specialist teachers, in a structured timetable with scheduled breaks. Deliberately small groups, so every learner is seen, heard and known.
- **Friday — Cornerstones Day** — Relational Intelligence, Digital Skills, RSHE, Sustainable Development Goal projects and creative work: the day the Cornerstones come alive in their own right, rather than being squeezed into academic sessions.

2.3 Who delivers, and who stays alongside

The staffing model is a deliberate separation of teaching from mentoring:

- **Qualified, subject-specialist teachers** deliver *all* live lessons. They are the curriculum's teaching engine.
- The named **Practitioner-Mentor** is the learner's consistent point of contact throughout their placement — building the relationship, co-ordinating with teachers, supporting pastorally, and holding the relationship with family and commissioner. The Practitioner-Mentor does **not** teach subjects or deliver lessons.
- The **Student Success Coordinator** leads onboarding and daily check-ins and is a recognisable first adult — a doorway to the DSL.
- Curriculum authorship sits with the **Curriculum Lead** (a fixed-term engagement to launch) and subject **Heads of Department**, with mathematics authored in partnership with The Novacene Ltd.

This separation is a safeguarding and quality feature, not an accident: the adult who holds the relationship is not the adult under pressure to deliver content.

2.4 Qualification pathways

Learners move between and combine four routes. The question is always "what does this young person need to make meaningful progress this term," not "which box does this child fit into."

- **Pearson Edexcel International GCSEs** — the core academic spine. At launch: English Language A (4EA1), English Literature (4ET1), Mathematics A (4MA1, Foundation or Higher tier), Human Biology (4HB1), and Art & Design (4FA1); Science Double Award (4SD0) planned for a future intake. Modular where possible so learners build credit over

time; coursework and portfolio routes used (English, Art) to take weight off the exam hall. **Examination entry fees are charged separately from tuition.** iGCSEs are globally recognised but are not regulated by Ofqual.

- **Functional Skills** — nationally recognised English, Maths and Digital Skills (Pearson Edexcel), a practical route alongside or towards iGCSE, with lower-stakes on-demand assessment.
- **ASDAN** — flexible, portfolio-based short courses and programmes recognising progress at the learner's own pace.
- **Discovery Phase** — a Cornerstones-led re-engagement scaffold for learners not yet ready for a full timetable or formal qualifications, with named goals and a clear route onward.

2.5 The Curriculum Vault as the operational backbone

The curriculum is not a static document; it is a live, navigable data structure — the **NEO Curriculum Vault** (Curriculum × Overlay schema v0.3). Every canonical outcome page carries a plain-English statement of the learning, its Cornerstone tag(s) with fit rating, its Mode(s), its place in the Curriculum spine, suggested evidence types, and suggested Mastery descriptors — and surfaces the awarding-body overlay outcomes that test it. A teacher planning a unit selects canonical outcomes and, where a learner is being prepared for a qualification, the overlay outcomes that map to them come with it.

2.6 How a subject curriculum is built to this intent — mathematics as the pilot

Mathematics is the first subject built to this intent, and the working pattern for those that follow. The existing GCSE maths content (authored as *Verse-al Maths*) has been duplicated into a NEO working repository ([neo-maths](#), held in The Novacene organisation until the authoring partner is paid, then transferred to Nudge Education) and is being re-based from the Ways of Knowing onto the Cornerstones. Sequencing follows the intent above: a broad Key Stage 3 with a strong Year 9 emphasis, then Year 10 as Year 1 of the iGCSE, mapped closely to the Pearson Edexcel International GCSE Mathematics A (4MA1) specification, with tiered entry so a learner meets maths where they actually are. The maths build is the proving ground for the Cornerstone design principles in §1.4; what is learned there feeds back into this document.

Part 3 — Impact

3.1 How progress is judged — the Mastery scale

NEO uses a **descriptor-based Mastery scale**, not numerical grades, lifted from the Teaching and Learning Policy v04.26:

Emerging → Developing → Secure → Mastering.

A learner's evidence carries one Mastery judgement per outcome demonstration. A single piece of work can evidence several outcomes at once — a canonical curriculum outcome, and one or more awarding-body overlay outcomes — each at its own level. This keeps the judgement about the *learning*, while still producing an auditable, exam-legible record.

3.2 Progress made visible — in real time

Impact is not filed away for termly reports. The platform gives the young person, their family, and the commissioner a live view — attendance, engagement, session-level notes in plain language, safeguarding flags, and progress against agreed goals, updated after every session. Three views — commissioner dashboard, parent-facing view, Practitioner-Mentor view — show the same facts, appropriately framed. (Referred to externally as real-time progress tracking.)

3.3 The learner owns the evidence — the portable portfolio

The curriculum's metadata travels with the learner's evidence into a **portable portfolio**. The school owns the canonical curriculum data; the learner owns their evidence. The awarding-body overlay annotations on that evidence make a learner's record portable and meaningful in an assessed world *without* that world owning them. The bundle renders into a human-readable portfolio, a commissioner-friendly evidence-by-outcome spreadsheet (the column that makes EHCP and OEAS reports auto-generable), and a learner-controlled network view.

3.4 Impact for learners with additional needs

Two auxiliary frames make impact legible for SEND and commissioning:

- **Preparing for Adulthood** (SEND Code of Practice) — employment; independent living; friends, relationships and community; good health — mapped most densely in life-and-work and ASDAN routes, and critical for EHCP outcome reporting.
- **Areas of Need** — communication and interaction; cognition and learning; social, emotional and mental health; sensory and physical — recording which delivery

approaches are designed with which learner profiles in mind. This matters most for the EBSNA cohort, where *how* something is taught matters as much as *what*.

3.5 Accreditation evidence — OEAS

The curriculum is designed to evidence the OEAS accreditation criteria directly: **curriculum breadth, curriculum balance, curriculum rigour, and teaching quality**. Every Vault node that helps evidence a criterion carries the relevant OEAS tag, so a single query produces the audit pack rather than a scramble before inspection.

3.6 The measure that matters most

Grades, mastery judgements and portfolios all matter. But the ultimate measure of this curriculum is **re-engagement** — a young person who had left learning behind choosing to show up, to try, and to believe again that it is safe to learn. Everything above is in service of that.

Governance, ownership and review

- **Owner of this document:** Director, Nudge Education Online & Head of School, until the Curriculum Lead is in post.
- **Approval:** this is a draft until reviewed and approved by the Head of School; the RSHE statutory strand is co-owned with the named RSHE lead; NEO-original and Verse-ality Certified content is co-stewarded with The Novacene Ltd as IP holder.
- **Review cadence:** annual, aligned to the Teaching and Learning Policy review (April), with an interim check-in at the September 2026 launch.

Open questions carried forward

1. **Nutrition as a universal design lens** (§1.4) — genuine design principle for every subject, or primarily contextual and Cornerstones-Day for abstract subjects? *Owner: Head of School + maths partner + Heads of Department.*
2. **Subject-agnostic skills** (§1.5) — confirm and define the cross-curricular capability set with Heads of Department.
3. **Ways-of-Knowing retirement** — confirm the maths content is fully re-based onto Cornerstones before it becomes the template for other subjects.
4. **Reconciliation** — check this document against the live Teaching and Learning Policy v04.26 and Curriculum Rationale v2.0, and fold the Rationale into this Intent/Implementation/Impact structure so there is a single keystone rather than two.
5. **Assessment access** — confirm iGCSE exam-centre / entry arrangements, since NEO does not run exams.

Attribution

Nudge Education Online is operated by **Nudge Education Ltd** (Company Number 10192753). The Cornerstones, Modes and Mastery scale are defined in the NEO Teaching and Learning Policy v04.26. The Curriculum × Overlay architecture is defined in the NEO Curriculum Vault Tagging Schema v0.3. The mathematics curriculum derives from *Verse-al Maths* and *Relating Intelligently* / Relational Intelligence is a NEO adaptation of Novacene work — both **The Novacene Ltd** IP, used by NEO under licence. This document is a working draft prepared in Cowork for review by the Head of School; it names roles, not individuals.

Connection before curriculum. Always.